HILCHOT SHABBAT

Soap, Snow & Sponges: Can You Use Soap on Shabbat?

Given Thursday 4 June 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat 320 Seifim 10-18 — מלאכת דש

Sefer: Shulchan Aruch · Orach Chaim **Siman:** 320 (ש"כ) **Topic:** מלאכת דש — Threshing & Squeezing (Continued) **Tonight's Seifim:** 10 (breaking ice) · 11 (washing hands with snow) · 12 (salt & soap) · 13 (walking on snow) · 14 (urinating in snow) · 15 (towel over water) · 16 (wedging cotton in a jug) · 17 (sponges) · Beginning 18 (the flax stopper & psik reisha d'lo nicha lei) **Plus:** Freezing water on Shabbat · The full discussion of soap · Introduction to Melaben's relationship with Dash

Recap — The Structure of Siman 320

Part	Seifim	Content
1	א–ח	Mefarek/Sechita: three categories of fruit, lemons, pickles, squeezing onto solids
2	ט–יד	Crushing ice and snow — the rabbinic extensions
3	טו–יח	Sechita of Melaben vs. Sechita of Dash — towels, sponges, stoppers
(End)	יט–כ	Melechet Tzovei'a (dyeing) — to be learned separately

Recap of Part 2 So Far (Last Week)

The Gemara: אין מרסקין לא את השלג ולא את הברד, אבל נותן הוא לתוך הכוס ואינו חושש — one may not crush snow or hail on Shabbat, but may put it into a cup.

Three reasons in the Rishonim:

Rishon	Reason	Nature of Problem
Rambam	similar to Dash — דומה לדש	The **action** of producing liquid from solid
Rashi	Similar to מכה בפטיש — creating something new	The **action**
Ba'al HaTerumah (Rabbeinu Baruch of Mainz)	**Nolad** — a new entity exists that didn't exist when Shabbat began	The **result**

The Shulchan Aruch clearly holds like Rambam (he placed these halachot in the Dash chapter) — and we'll see tonight he also incorporates Rashi's reasoning.

Practical results established last week:

- **Leaving ice to melt on its own**: Sefardim permitted (Rashi/Rambam — no action); Ashkenazim should not in the first instance (Ba'al HaTerumah/Rema — the result is the problem)
- **Putting ice cubes into a drink**: Permitted by all (the transformation is never discernible — immediately mixed in)
- **Crushing the ice once it's in the drink**: Ba'al HaTerumah permits (result is absorbed); Rashi/Rambam — machloket; **Shulchan Aruch rules strictly** → Sefardim should not crush ice cubes in their Coke; Ashkenazim have room to be lenient

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Seif 10 — Breaking Ice to Reach the Water

It is permitted to break ice in order to take the water **מותר לשבר הקרח כדי ליטול מים מתחתיו** *beneath it.*

The Case

A frozen pool/mikveh/body of water on a cold morning — you may break the ice to reach the water underneath (e.g., for tevillah).

The Gemara in Berachot says **Benayahu ben Yehoyada** broke the ice to immerse in a mikveh — and there are many Chassidic stories of the same.

The Question

We just learned you may NOT crush ice! Why is breaking ice permitted?

The Answer — Intention

Look back at Seif 9: the prohibition is crushing **כדי שיזובו מימיו** — *in order that its water should flow*. The entire rabbinic prohibition (under all three reasons) is when your purpose is to CREATE liquid.

Here, you're breaking the ice **to access the water beneath** — not to convert the ice into water. Some liquid will incidentally result, but that's not your intention. **Permitted.**

The Magen Avraham's Concern (Rejected)

The Magen Avraham suggested that breaking ice attached to the ground (a river) might be a problem of **stira** (destruction). **All the Poskim disagreed** — water has no binyan u'stira. **Chacham Ovadia rules outright: permitted.**

Important Application for Ashkenazim

Based on this seif, the Ashkenazi Poskim qualify their stringency about leaving ice out to melt:

- **Problem**: Leaving ice out for an extended period **with the intention** that it melt into liquid
- **NOT a problem**: Taking ice cubes out of the freezer before serving so they soften slightly and can be extracted — some melting happens *mimela* (automatically), but you're not doing it **כדי שיזובו מימיו**

The Ashkenazi stringency only applies to intentional transformation. Incidental melting in the normal course of use is permitted for everyone.

Seif 11 — Washing Hands with Snow/Ice Water in Winter

צריך ליזהר בחורף שלא יטול ידיו במים שיש בהם שלג או ברד, ואם יטול — יזהר שלא ידחקם בין ידיו שלא יהיה מרסק

In winter, one should be careful not to wash one's hands with water containing snow or ice. If one does wash — be careful not to press them between the hands, so as not to crush.

The Halacha

- Better not to wash hands with water containing snow/ice
- If you do — don't rub/press your hands together, because you'd be **crushing the ice into liquid** (and there you WANT the extra liquid to wash with)

Critical Inference

Notice: the ice here is already mixed **with liquid water** — and still the Shulchan Aruch says don't crush it. **This proves the Shulchan Aruch holds you cannot crush solids even when they're sitting in liquid.**

This confirms what we said on Seif 9: **Sefardim should not crush ice cubes in their drink on Shabbat.**

(Side note from Rabbi Kada: whether netilat yadayim itself works with snow is a separate question — likely problematic since it's not "mayim" — to be checked separately.)

Side Topic — Freezing Water on Shabbat

The Question: It's a hot summer Shabbat afternoon, the ice cubes have run out. May I put water in the freezer for tonight?

(If it's for after Shabbat → forbidden as hachana. The question is for use later the same Shabbat.)

The Analysis

Opinion	Ruling	Why
Rambam / Rashi (Sefardim)	**Permitted — no issue at all**	The entire prohibition is an *action* of crushing (similar to Dash / Makeh B'Patish). Putting liquid in a freezer involves no action of crushing — it freezes on its own
Ba'al HaTerumah (Ashkenazi concern)	Question arises	If the problem is *creating something new* even passively — isn't freezing also transforming liquid → solid?

The Ashkenazi Resolution — Majority Lenient

A minority of Ashkenazi poskim forbid. But **the majority are lenient** — including the **Shevet HaLevi (Rav Wosner)** and **Orchot Shabbat**. Two reasons given:

1. **The Ba'al HaTerumah's chiddush was specifically solid → liquid** — creating *water*, which is more useful than the solid. Going the other way (liquid → solid) was never part of the prohibition.
2. **The prohibition only covers things subject to crushing (risuk)** — a liquid cannot be "crushed" into a solid, so the gezeira never applied.

Bottom Line

Everyone may freeze water into ice cubes on Shabbat (for use that same Shabbat).

Seif 12 — Salt (and the Gateway to Soap)

יש ליזהר שלא ישפשף ידיו במלח *One should be careful not to rub one's hands with salt.*

The Halacha

Don't rub salt between your hands — you'd be **dissolving/transforming the solid salt particles into liquid**, just like crushing ice into water.

Working It Through the Three Reasons

Opinion	Does the salt prohibition make sense?
Rashi (Makeh B'Patish — creating something new)	✓ Yes — transforming salt to liquid creates something new
Ba'al HaTerumah (Nolad — the result)	✓ Yes — a new liquid now exists
Rambam (Domeh l'Dash)	✗ **No issue!** Dash requires something *omed l'mashkin* — something with liquid-potential like fruit, or even snow/ice. **Salt is not omed l'mashkeh** — there's no resemblance to Dash

The **Mishna Berura** writes this explicitly: according to the Rambam, salt and borit (soap) and other things not designated for liquid would be **permitted l'chatchila**.

The Shulchan Aruch's Dual Position

Interesting observation: the Shulchan Aruch:

1. Placed these halachot in the Dash chapter → holds like **Rambam**
2. But ALSO forbids rubbing salt → that's only explicable like **Rashi**

Conclusion: the Shulchan Aruch incorporates both reasonings (Rambam AND Rashi) — but certainly not the Ba'al HaTerumah.

The Big Application — Soap on Shabbat (Bar of Soap)

The Rema's Ruling (Siman 326:10)

ואסור לרחוץ ידיו במלח, וכל שכן בבורית שקורין סאבו"ן, דהוי נולד *It is forbidden to wash one's hands with salt, and all the more so with borit called "sabon" (soap) — for it is nolad.*

Just as you can't transform ice → liquid or salt → liquid, **you cannot rub a bar of soap into liquid** on Shabbat. This is how the **Ben Ish Chai** and many Sefardi poskim rule — forbidden.

The Ben Ish Chai explicitly rejects the lenient view: even though while washing, the soap mixes with water droplets already on your hands (and we've learned that transformation INTO existing liquid is permitted) — he still forbids, and says this is the minhag.

The Lenient View — Pachad Yitzchak & Ginat Veradim

The **Pachad Yitzchak** distinguishes:

> **אבל הבורית מצד עצמו לא יהפך למים, אלא על ידי המים עולה קצף על ידיו, ואין דמיון לבורית עם השלג והברד**

- Snow/ice/salt → **directly transform into liquid water**
- Soap → does NOT become water. It becomes **ketzef — FOAM** — via the water
- Foam is not a liquid → no comparison to snow and ice → **no prohibition**

The Second Issue Everyone Asks About — Memachek (Smoothing)

Most people think the reason soap is forbidden on Shabbat is **Memachek** (smoothing — like smoothing wax over a barrel opening). But notice: **the Rema never mentions Memachek!** He only raises nolad.

Chacham Ben Tzion Abba Shaul and Chacham Ovadia derive from this a very important principle:

Memareach/Memachek is only forbidden when you are smoothing something in order to make it smooth — creating a smooth layer you want (like wax sealing a barrel).

Applied to soap:

- **The lather smoothed on your hands?** You have zero interest in it — it's washed off seconds later. Not Memachek at all.
- **The smoothing of the bar itself?** You have no intention for that — it's a **פסיק רישא דלא ניחא ליה** (inevitable but of no benefit to you) on what is at worst a d'Rabbanan — **permitted**.
- *(BUT: if you deliberately rub the bar to make it nice and smooth — which people sometimes do — that is forbidden according to everyone.)*

The Final Ruling on Soap

Issue	Analysis
Nolad / transforming solid → liquid	It becomes foam, not liquid → machloket on a d'Rabbanan → safek d'Rabbanan l'kula
Memachek	No interest in the smoothness → psik reisha d'lo nicha lei on a d'Rabbanan → permitted

Chacham Ovadia: Mikar hadin, **one may use a bar of soap on Shabbat** — but **ba'al nefesh yachmir** (a scrupulous person should be stringent).

Practical guidance:

- If you see people using bar soap on Shabbat — they have what to rely on; no need to correct them
- If you have **liquid soap** available — use it and avoid the whole question

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Seif 13 — Walking on Snow

> **דורס שלג ברגליו ואינו חושש** *.One may tread on snow with his feet and need not be concerned*

The Halacha

You may walk on snow on Shabbat (to shul, to a friend) — even though your steps crush it.

Two Reasons in the Acharonim

Posek	Reason
Vilna Gaon	you have no intention to crush — **אינו מתכוון**
Taz (Rabbi David Segal)	it's impossible to avoid; there's no alternative (you can't stay — **אי אפשר ליזהר** trapped at home all Shabbat)

Nafka Mina 1 — Half the Pavement Is Clear

Part of the pavement has snow, part is clear:

- **Taz**: You must walk on the clear side — the whole heter is that there's no alternative
- **Vilna Gaon**: Walk wherever is easiest — you're not intending to crush either way
- **Ben Ish Chai rules strictly (like the Taz)**: if there's an alternative route, take it

Nafka Mina 2 — Enjoying the Crunch

The road is fully snowed; you must walk through it. But you *enjoy* crunching snow (we all know that feeling — wellies on, stomping the snow) and deliberately walk harder to crush it:

- **Taz**: No problem — there's no alternative route anyway
- **Vilna Gaon**: Problem — you're now **mitkaven** (intending) to crush

Agreed by Both

Going out to jump on snow in order to crush it (teenagers/adults for fun) — forbidden according to both reasons: you're either mitkaven (Gra) or have an alternative (Taz — you don't need to be doing this at all).

(Rabbi Kada: I wouldn't stop young children doing this — no need for chinuch on something like this.)

Walking on Ice

Same status as snow — permitted where needed. (Though probably inadvisable for safety reasons!)

Seif 14 — Urinating in Snow

The Maharam of Rothenburg permits **מהר"ם מרוטנבורג מתיר להטיל מי רגלים בשלג, והרא"ש נזהר** *.urinating in snow; the Rosh was careful (not to)*

A Teacher-Student Machloket

The Rosh (Rabbeinu Asher) was the **student** of the Maharam MiRotenburg. (Historical note: the Maharam spent years imprisoned; the Rosh fled the German persecutions to Toledo.)

The Positions

- **Maharam**: Permitted — same logic as walking on snow (no intention to crush / no alternative)

- **Rosh**: Be careful not to — here you're **directly** causing the solid to change to liquid (more like crushing an ice cube in liquid than like incidentally stepping on snow)

The Halacha

- **If there's any need** — one may be lenient (it's d'Rabbanan, plus kavod haberiyot)
- If there's truly nowhere else to go — everyone agrees it's permitted
- Only one doing so **in order to** melt the snow would have a problem (an unusual case)

Seif 15 — A Towel Over the Water Bowl (Sechita of MELABEN)

Introduction — The Two Sechitot

This is the key conceptual distinction for Part 3 of the siman. **There are two melachot of squeezing, and your intention determines which one applies:**

Melacha	What You Want	Example
Dash (Mefarek)	You want **the liquid being squeezed out**	Squeezing grapes for juice, olives for oil
Melaben (laundering)	You want **the garment** — squeezing to *get rid of* the liquid	Wringing out a soaked cloth

Melaben Has Three Torah-Level Components

soaking the garment — **שריה (Sheriyah)**

scrubbing/rubbing it — **שפשוף (Shifshuf)**

wringing it out (an essential part of laundering — removing the dirty water) — **סחיטה (Sechita)**

Both melachot are called "sechita" — which is confusing. Squeezing to USE the liquid = Dash. Squeezing to REMOVE the liquid from the item you want = Melaben. **This distinction recurs throughout Hilchot Shabbat.**

The Halacha of Seif 15

אסור לפרוס סודר על פי החבית וליתן על גביו כלי ששואבים בו, שמא יבוא לידי סחיטה. אבל בגד העשוי לפרוס עליו — מותר, שאינו חושש עליו לסוחטו

The Case

Many people keep a netilat yadayim set by their bed (bowl + cup of water — so as not to walk daled amot in the morning without washing). The Ben Ish Chai and other poskim also note you shouldn't leave water uncovered (mayim megulim) — so people cover the cup with a towel.

The Ruling

- **A regular cloth/towel/garment** spread over a water vessel → **FORBIDDEN** — out of concern it will dip into the water and you'll come to **squeeze it out** (sechita of **Melaben** — you want the towel dry, not the liquid)

- **A cloth designated for this use** (your regular netilat yadayim hand towel) → **PERMITTED** — since its nature is to be used with water and be wet, you won't care to squeeze it

Practical

- Your regular hand towel from the netilat yadayim set → fine to use as a cover on Shabbat
- Friday night and your hand towels are in the wash, so you grab a random shirt or fresh towel from the closet → **forbidden** to use as the cover

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Seif 16 — Wedging Wet Cotton into a Jug Opening (Sechita of DASH)

אסור להדק מוכין בפי פך שיש בו משקין, משום סחיטה *It is forbidden to wedge soft material (cotton/wadding) into the mouth of a flask containing liquid, because of sechita.*

The Case

A jug stoppered with soft material (cotton wadding). The wadding is **wet** (it's been sitting in the jug opening). Pressing it back in = **psik reisha** — you will inevitably squeeze liquid out of it **into the jug**.

Which Sechita Is This?

DASH — because the squeezed drops go INTO the jug, adding to your liquid. It's **nicha lei** (beneficial to you) — even a few drops add to your wine/liquid. You're extracting liquid that you keep.

(Note the confusion: Seif 15's sechita was Melaben; Seif 16's sechita is Dash. Same word, different melachot.)

Even Designated Material

Unlike Seif 15 (where a designated cloth was fine), here even designated wadding is a problem — because the issue isn't "you might come to squeeze" (a concern); it's that wedging it **inevitably squeezes** liquid into the jug right now.

Seif 17 — Sponges

ספוג — אין מקנחין בו אלא אם כן יש בו בית אחיזה, גזרה שמא יסחוט *A sponge — one may not wipe with it unless it has a handle...*

Correction on the Language

The Shulchan Aruch says "gezera shema yischot" but the Gemara's reasoning is **mishum sechita** — it's not a *gezera* (precaution), it's **psik reisha**: holding a wet handle-less sponge and wiping a table **inevitably** squeezes liquid out.

Which Sechita?

DASH — as you wipe, you squeeze liquid out of the sponge and **use that liquid to clean** the surface. You want the extracted liquid → Dash.

The Halacha

Sponge	Status
Wet sponge, **no handle**	**Forbidden** — psik reisha of squeezing
Wet sponge **with a handle** (בית אחיזה)	**Permitted** — no longer inevitable; you use the surface moisture only (still be careful not to squeeze)

Beginning Seif 18 — The Flax Stopper & Psik Reisha D'Lo Nicha Lei

This is the major final seif of the Dash/Melaben section. Tonight we lay the groundwork; we'll finish next shiur.

Introduction Point 1 — Is There Libun (Laundering) with Liquids Other Than Water?

(Based on the sugya in Ketubot daf 5-6 and the famous Tosafot there.)

The Question: Melaben means squeezing out to clean. Does it apply when the absorbed liquid is NOT water — e.g., a towel drenched in **red wine** or **Coca-Cola**?

Opinion	Ruling	Logic
Rambam (and others)	**YES — יש ליבון בשאר משקין** — squeezing out wine IS Melaben (d'Oraita)	Even though the stain and smell remain, you've certainly improved the garment
Rabbeinu Tam (and many Rishonim)	**NO — אין ליבון בשאר משקין**	Laundering means *cleaning*. Squeeze out water → garment is clean. Squeeze out wine → still dirty. That's not laundering

Key for the psak: the Shulchan Aruch rules NOT like the Rambam — there is NO libun with other liquids. (Squeezing wine out of a cloth is not Melaben.)

Introduction Point 2 — Dash V'Holech L'Ibud (Squeezing Where the Liquid Goes to Waste)

Setup: Clearly, squeezing an expensive wine OUT of a towel INTO a cup (to save the wine) = **Dash from the Torah** — you want the extracted liquid.

The Question: What if I squeeze the wine out of the towel and it **goes to waste** (down the drain)? No Melaben issue (per the Shulchan Aruch's ruling — wine isn't libun). Is the squeezing itself a Dash problem?

Opinion	Ruling	Logic
Rabbeinu Tam	**Assur d'Rabbanan**	It's Dash performed as a מלאכה שאינה צריכה לגופה (extraction not for the sake of using the extract)
Other Rishonim	**Muttar**	Squeezing-to-waste simply ISN'T Dash. The essence of Dash-sechita is *wanting what comes out*. Squeezing to discard falls under the *category* of Melaben — and if the liquid has no libun (wine), it's permitted entirely

The Seif Itself (Begun)

חבית שפקקה בפקק של פשתן שמוצין בה היין, יש מי שמתיר (להסירו) אף על פי שאי אפשר שלא יסחוט

A barrel stoppered with a flax stopper through which wine is drawn — there is one who permits (removing/reinserting it) even though it is impossible not to squeeze.

(Textual note: the word להסירו was added by the Mishna Berura's explanation and copied into modern editions — it's not in the original Shulchan Aruch text. The meaning: to remove and reinsert the stopper.)

The Famous Opinion — The Ba'al HaAruch

This is the celebrated position of the **Aruch** (one of the early Rishonim):

> A psik reisha (inevitable consequence) in which you have **פסיק רישא דלא ניחא ליה — מותר no interest** — is **PERMITTED**, even where the melacha would be d'Oraita.

Defining "Lo Nicha Lei" Precisely

Critical clarification: *Lo nicha lei* does NOT mean "it's bad for me." It means **"I have no interest / no benefit in it."**

Proof from Tosafot: the Gemara's case of watering **בארעא דחבריה** (a friend's field) — the water benefits the friend's land, nothing bad happens — yet it's still called *psik reisha d'lo nicha lei* because **I** have no interest in it. Indifference qualifies as *lo nicha lei*.

To Be Continued Next Shiur

- Completing Seif 18: how the machloket about psik reisha d'lo nicha lei plays out
- The Mishna Berura's treatment and halacha l'ma'aseh applications
- Then: **Melechet Tzovei'a** (dyeing) — the final two seifim of the siman

(Note: no shiur next Thursday; regular shiurim otherwise — Monday HaMaspik, Tuesday Moreh.)

Summary Table of Tonight's Halachot

Seif	Topic	Bottom Line
10	Breaking ice to reach water	**Permitted** — intention is access, not liquid creation
11	Washing hands with snow/ice water	Avoid; if you do — don't rub hands together
—	Freezing water into ice cubes	**Permitted for everyone** (for that Shabbat's use)
12	Rubbing salt	Forbidden (Shulchan Aruch incorporates Rashi's reason)
—	**Bar of soap**	Mikar hadin **permitted** (foam ≠ liquid; no Memachek interest); ba'al nefesh yachmir; liquid soap avoids the question
13	Walking on snow	**Permitted**; don't deliberately stomp to crush; Ben Ish Chai: take a clear path if one exists
14	Urinating in snow	Maharam permits, Rosh careful; lenient if any need
15	Towel over water bowl	Designated towel — permitted; random garment — forbidden (Melaben concern)
16	Wet cotton wedged in jug	Forbidden — psik reisha of Dash (drops squeezed into your liquid)
17	Wet sponge	Forbidden without a handle; permitted with one
18	Flax stopper (begun)	The Aruch: psik reisha d'lo nicha lei is permitted — to be continued

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B'Ezrat Hashem

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